

Figure 2.1 Digital relationships occupy a space where transactional, interactional, and exploitative dynamics combine in varying degrees. Understanding which type of relationship your system supports is critical for designing effective identity and authorization policies.

Most of the relationships we create online are transactional. I have a rich relationship with Amazon that has been in development for over 25 years. Amazon knows a great deal about me and uses that information to further its goal of selling products and services to me. I use the relationship to buy the things I need to live and work. But the relationship is, at its heart, transactional.

On the other hand, I have an interactional relationship with many of my healthcare providers using their various patient portals. Some of what transpires is transactional when I use it to schedule appointments or pay my bills. But much of it is interactional, discussing medical conditions, updates to prescriptions, or questions I have about treatment.

The type of relationship being supported should shape both the design of the identity system and the policies that govern access. In a transactional relationship, identity attributes may be needed only briefly, and the system